

The key to a fruitful side hustle is to be passionate about the subject matter. My girlfriend and I just started selling custom-designed LGBTQ-themed hand towels online because we can make a little profit. (And I love danger. Spontaneously starting a small business with a romantic partner? Let's do this.) We care about the LGBTQ community. Sam cares about Beyoncé. My other friend loves graphic design. My dad enjoys driving and meeting new people. Can every job be 100 percent enjoyable? Sadly, no. Most aren't. But it helps if what you're doing in your free time makes you money and fulfills something you're maybe not getting in your day job. Or, like in my case, you need multiple income streams to keep you afloat.

I always keep the idea of the side hustle in my back pocket. If a brand takes a full year to cut me a check (which happens), I sell old action figures online to keep myself in the black. If our monthly YouTube ads payment is low, I bring clothes over to Buffalo Exchange so I don't overdraw my account. My girlfriend and my towel idea came from a particularly bad crying session where I was running low on cash and waiting for too many unpredictable freelance payments. The gig economy lives on.

HOW TO APPLY FOR UNEMPLOYMENT

Just in case your side hustle isn't cutting it, each state has a different process for unemployment application, but it's worth doing if you've been fired from your job or otherwise qualify. After you're approved, it usually takes two to three weeks to start receiving checks to tide you over. You can apply on the website for your state's unemployment services or by calling its offices, mailing in a form, or going to the office in person. (Talking to a real person? Awful. Just kidding, just kidding.)

When I applied for unemployment, it was in California, and I did it by printing out and mailing in the forms. I'm not sure why. Maybe I thought it was more official. Either way, I ended up being denied because it was determined I'd technically quit, but the application for unemployment was pretty basic. (You have to give the reason you no longer have a job and prove you were let go through no fault of your own. I did not prove that. That's on me.)